favourite epidemiologist Washington D.C.-based Dr Ramanan Laxminarayan, at the Center for Disease Dynamics, Economics & Policy, had said in the early months of 2021, 'India suffered through a lot and because it suffered through a lot, it's reached the other shore now. I don't see the prospect of a second wave in India. If it does happen, it will likely be a modest one.'[6] Similar echoes were sounded by Bhramar Mukherjee at the University of Michigan, 'There is a human barricade for the virus. By the end of March 2021, we should see a very slow, steady decline in cases.'[7] Dr V. Ramasubramanian of Apollo Hospitals had also said, 'Probably the severity of the second wave would be much milder because 60 percent of our population is younger. The second wave would be far milder than what the US and UK are witnessing. We are seeing a surge in several states, but it will not be as severe as the first one and would be shorter and fizzle out sooner.'[8] Dr Shahid Jameel, director of the Trivedi School of Biosciences at Ashoka University, had also noted, 'India's first wave was quite broad. The peak was not very sharp. As a result of that I think India may not have, what we traditionally call, a second wave. This is entirely my hypothesis.'[9] Dr T. Jacob, virologist and former professor at CMC Vellore, had commented that, 'The coronavirus epidemic seems to be nearing its end and is likely to transition to the endemic phase in a month or two.' Dr Rahul Pandit, director of Critical Care Medicine & ICU at Fortis and member of Maharashtra COVID-19 Task Force, had also failed to predict of Mumbai, which did bear the heavy brunt of the second wave, stating, 'Mumbai is slowly approaching closer to the end of the pandemic. There are several pockets in the city that have already developed herd immunity.'[10] None predicted that in a couple of months India will be engulfed by the wrath of the virus. Even the Congress party leaders thought on the same lines. In an article written by P. Chidambaram on 10 January, his first line was, 'The pandemic seems to be on its way out, but not gone yet. The vaccine seems to be on its way in, but has not yet reached households. The one thing that has remained unmoved is controversy!'[11]

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Possibly encouraged by the smooth experience from Bihar and from other parts of the world in addition to the scientists' opinion of the country reaching some kind of an endemic stage, the Election Commission (EC)